

THE STONE AGE — PALAEOLITHIC AND MESOLITHIC

INDIAN PREHISTORY: TECHNOLOGY • LANDSCAPES • LIFEWAYS • EVIDENCE LIMITS
Core first • regional chronology • no tool=people equation • qualified transition

1

MASTER QUESTION AND EVIDENCE RULE

- EVIDENCE**How can text-free deep time become evidence-based history?
- MECHANIS**LITHICS + STRATIGRAPHY + DATES + FAUNA/FLORA + BODIES + ART + LANDSCAPE
- LIMIT**OBSERVE -> ASSOCIATE -> DATE -> INTERPRET -> QUALIFY
- VERDICT**Verdict: material abundance permits history, but confidence varies by context.

ANSWER LINE: Evidence becomes history only through context and qualification.

2

CHRONOLOGY WITHOUT A PAN-INDIAN LADDER

- EVIDENCE**Lower Palaeolithic -> Middle Palaeolithic -> Upper Palaeolithic -> Mesolithic
- MECHANIS**bifaces/core-flake -> prepared flakes -> blades/burins -> microlithic composites
- LIMIT**MACRO PHASE -> REGIONAL SEQUENCE -> DATED STRATUM -> ASSEMBLAGE
- VERDICT**Transitions overlap; phase labels are neither races nor universal dates.

ANSWER LINE: Broad phases guide; regional sequences decide.

3

PLEISTOCENE-HOLOCENE AND DATING

- EVIDENCE**Climate/river/sea-level change -> resources shift -> human choices change
- MECHANIS**Stratigraphy = relative order | radiocarbon = suitable organics
- LIMIT**Luminescence = mineral exposure event | typology = comparison, not sole date
- VERDICT**A date belongs first to the sampled event; redeposition and error matter.

ANSWER LINE: Date the event; then argue the association.

4

LITHIC OPERATIONAL CHAIN

- EVIDENCE**RAW STONE -> CORE -> FLAKE/BLADE -> RETOUCH/BACKING -> HAFT/USE -> DISCARD
- MECHANIS**Read cortex, hammerstones, rough-outs, debitage, wear, residues and spicing.
- LIMIT**Primary context preserves activity relation; secondary context is displaced.
- VERDICT**Tool form suggests function; assemblage and use evidence test it.

ANSWER LINE: Read the reduction chain, not only the finished tool.

5

LOWER PALAEOLITHIC AND ACHEULIAN

- EVIDENCE**Acheulian = assemblage marked by bifacial handaxes and cleavers.
- MECHANIS**Also retain choppers, flakes, cores, hammerstones and resharpening debris.
- LIMIT**Soanian/Madrasian cannot be treated as sealed races or civilisations.
- VERDICT**Technology records learned choices, not one hominin species.

ANSWER LINE: Acheulian is technology, never a race.

6

REGIONAL LOWER PALAEOLITHIC LANDSCAPES

- EVIDENCE**Soan-Siwalki: terrace lithics + fluvial caution
- MECHANIS**Attirampakkam: deep Acheulian -> early regional Middle Palaeolithic transition
- LIMIT**Hungsi-Baichba/Isampur: water + quarry + manufacture + habitation
- VERDICT**Bhimbetka/Narmada/Son/Belan: recurrent corridors with different contexts.

ANSWER LINE: Indian sequences are landscapes, not isolated type-sites.

7

NARMADA HOMININ CONTROL

- EVIDENCE**1982 Arun Sonakia -> Hathnora cranial fragment in Narmada gravel context
- MECHANIS**Associated fauna and nearby late Acheulian tools; later central-valley finds
- LIMIT**Competing labels: advanced Homo erectus / archaic Homo sapiens / intermediate
- VERDICT**Safe claim: rare archaic hominin evidence; age, taxon and authorship debated.

ANSWER LINE: Hathnora is decisive evidence with unresolved classification.

8

MIDDLE PALAEOLITHIC

- EVIDENCE**Flakes + scrapers + points + borers; older bifaces may continue.
- MECHANIS**LEVALLOIS: shape convexities -> prepare platform -> detach planned flake
- LIMIT**Attirampakkam, Nevasa, Didwana and Son-Belan show regional sequences.
- VERDICT**Levallois is a method, not a finished tool or biological population.

ANSWER LINE: Prepared-core planning changed production without total replacement.

9

UPPER PALAEOLITHIC

- EVIDENCE**Parallel-sided blades + burins + some bone tools
- MECHANIS**Kurnool caves: organic tools/fauna | Patne/Bhimbetka: eggshell ornaments
- LIMIT**Ochre, beads and special objects widen evidence for communication.
- VERDICT**Symbolism is supportable; exact ritual, deity or social code is not.

ANSWER LINE: Symbolic evidence broadens history but does not decode belief.

10

LIFEWAYS AND INFERENCE LIMITS

- EVIDENCE**Plants + game + fish + turtles + shellfish -> broad flexible subsistence
- MECHANIS**Quarry -> task camp -> recurrent camp -> shelter = linked settlement system
- LIMIT**Fire/hearth claims require anthropogenic burning in secure context.
- VERDICT**Sharing and learning are plausible; rank and gender need independent evidence.

ANSWER LINE: Mobility was organised; social institutions remain partly hidden.

11

MESOLITHIC TECHNOLOGY AND RESIDENCE

- EVIDENCE**Fine stone -> bladelet -> backed/geometric microlith -> composite implement
- MECHANIS**Broad-spectrum niches -> processing/storage -> varied residence
- LIMIT**Microliths can pre-date the Holocene and continue with food production.
- VERDICT**Semi-sedentism needs a bundle: deposits, huts, hearths, seasonality, burials.

ANSWER LINE: Mesolithic change combined composite tools and varied residence.

12

MESOLITHIC REGIONAL MAP

- EVIDENCE**Bagor: long sequence + disputed domesticates | Langhnaj: burials/wild fauna
- MECHANIS**Adamgarh: long sequence; date/stratigraphy caution | Bhimbetka: layered art
- LIMIT**Sarai Nahar Rai/Mahadaha/Damdama: wetlands + burials + longer residence
- VERDICT**Chopani Mando: huts/grinding/wild rice | Baghor II: microlith manufacture.

ANSWER LINE: Shared microliths did not erase regional economies.

13

BURIALS, ROCK ART AND TRANSITION

- EVIDENCE**Burial -> treatment/memory; belief, kinship and hierarchy need patterns.
- MECHANIS**Bhimbetka superimposition -> relative order; paintings span several periods.
- LIMIT**Grinding/pottery/wild rice -> processing/use, not automatic cultivation.
- VERDICT**Foraging, management, herding and cultivation overlapped regionally.

ANSWER LINE: Burial, art and food-production claims need inference ladders.

14

UPSC EXECUTION AND QUALIFIED VERDICT

- EVIDENCE**PRELIMS: period + region + technology + certainty; eliminate category errors.
- MECHANIS**2019 Denisovan: archaic human population; no Indian fossil claim follows.
- LIMIT**MAINS: claim -> named site/assemblage -> analysis -> qualification -> comparison.
- VERDICT**VERDICT: Indian prehistory is a regional mosaic; not a teleological ladder.

ANSWER LINE: Map phase to tool, site to evidence and every claim to its limit.

QUALIFIED VERDICT: A REGIONAL MOSAIC OF CONTINUITY AND INNOVATION, RECONSTRUCTED FROM UNEVEN MATERIAL EVIDENCE.